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Anne Gardner, *Dan 8, 1-2: Keynote to the Following Vision and Advice to the Righteous* Pag. 429

Scholars see Dan 8,1-2 only as a bridge between Daniel 7 and 8, although the repetitive nature of verse 2, the exact location of the named places and the feasibility of Daniel being present in them have been much discussed. The present paper claims Dan 8,1-2 alludes to earlier Biblical passages, thereby providing the keynote to the coming vision – that it pertains to Jerusalem and a time of persecution which is a divine judgment on sin – as well as advice to the righteous to hold firm. Even though they might suffer, ultimately they will be vindicated and their enemies punished.

Gabor Ambrus, *Love, Number, Symbol: the Figure of the Rotae Ezekiel in Joachim of Fiore* » 451

Through its central caption *Caritas*, Joachim of Fiore's diagrammatic figure of the *Rotae Ezekiel* has a message centred upon the idea of love. This caption assumes various meanings in the rich context offered by the multiplicity of those further captions and inscriptions that make up the figure. Although the geometrical array of the multiple fourfold groups of these captions and inscriptions constitutes what may be called a "cosmic order" governed by the number four, such numerical logic is not sufficient to account for the truth of the figure as a whole. Instead, the *Rotae Ezekiel* should be seen as a symbol in the medieval sense, enabling various descents and ascents of love, whether human or divine.

Sergio Apruzzese, *I Cavalieri dello spirito per la pedagogia della nazione*. » 475

This article explores the contribution made by the the early twentieth century, Milan-based magazine *Il Rinnovamento* to the spread of nationalism, understood as an attitude towards life and intellectual sensibility of the young children of a newly united Italy. Through the





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analysis of the articles and publications by the protagonists of the journal, the article describes how it originated from the its director, duke Tommaso Gallarati Scotti: the myth of Italy as the nation of God, the elements that composed it, and the forms it assumed in other personalities connected to the journal. The myth of Italy as the nation of God was able to influence, if not surpass, the liberal-Catholic matrix of the magazine, and was able to generate a modern thought radically alternative to the modernity of the liberal-positivist modernity of Italy in the age of Giovanni Giolitti.

Isabella Adinolfi, *Il nome di Dio in Etty Hillesum. Silenzio e parola* Pag. 529

The article aims to investigate the semantic and evocative value that Etty Hillesum attributes in her diaries to the word “God”. The spiritual path of the young Jewish writer plays an important role here beginning with her contact with the Jungian psychotherapist Julius Spier in 1941, in light of the reception of his literary models and in particular of the German poet Rainer M. Rilke. After a section devoted to the literary and personal reasons that hindered Hillesum’s naming of God, the essay focuses on the “tiring journey”, the inner progress that leads the writer to transform her interior difficulties in space for the ineffable, mystical experience of God: a divine love of God that can be discovered at the same time internally and externally, impersonally and personally, at transcendent and immanent levels.

NOTE

Enrico Norelli, *Ancora sulla genesi dell'Ascensione di Isaia. Alcune osservazioni a partire dal contributo di Jonathan Knight* *The Ascension of Isaiah: A New Theory of Composition* » 549

In an essay published in «Cristianesimo nella storia», 1 (2014), Jonathan Knight outlines a new theory on the composition of the *Ascension of Isaiah*. The role of the apocryphal work in the investigation of certain environments of Early Christianity and the initial developments of Christology has been increasingly recognised in the past few decades. Enrico Norelli draws on this article in order to raise questions and propose a different interpretation.

Domenico Pazzini, *Chiesa e storia in Origene. Dieci anni di studi (2001-2011)* » 568

The growing and surprising interest in the work of Origen suggests an opportunity for a review of the literature published in the first ten years of the 21st century. Two themes - Church and history - represent the





central strand. This essay is divided into four parts: Church, Easter, history, prayer. Origen has a spiritual rather than institutional ecclesiology; Origen's Commentary on the Song of Songs is the most biblical and but also the most Greek of his work. The overcoming of a typological vision of Easter is also visible: the Eucharist is disconnected from Easter understood as sacrifice. History then emerges as typical of the *Origenesforschung*: it re-discuss the concept of *aeon*, the assumption of creating intelligible eternity, and the idea of *apokatastasis*. Prayer, examined in Origen's *Treaty on Prayer*, and in all the writings of Origen and in a comparative look with other authors (especially Augustine), is a very relevant theme of the spirituality and theology of Origen.

Carlo Pelliccia, *I gesuiti in Giappone (1908-2008): a proposito di una recente pubblicazione. Contributo a una ricostruzione storiografica*. Pag. 591

The essay draws on the volume *Japan Province of the Society of Jesus Recollections Centennial 1908-2008*, the English translation of the original *Hyakunen no Kioku: Iezusukai Sairainichi Isseiki kara*, published to celebrate the first hundred years of the return of the Jesuits in Japan in 1908. The author analyzed and deepened the salient aspects of the missionary history and the works of the apostolate and the religious who are engaged in the socio-cultural and religious conditions of Japan. The footnotes provide ideas and bibliographic information about the world and the peculiar characteristics of the world of the Jesuits and of the Society of Jesus.

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Love, Number, Symbol: the Figure of the *Rotae Ezekiel* in Joachim of Fiore

In taking the risk of speaking about love, one must pay keen attention to the context in which one has come to this far too popular, and thereby equally precarious, concept. We read in Scripture that «God is love» (1 John 4:8) and «love never fails» (1 Corinthians 13:8), but we should not forget that what guarantees the authenticity of the Johannine and Pauline statements about love is the authors' deep consideration of the multiple contexts in which they write to their addressees. While it is true that many kinds of concepts are to be seen and used against multiple backgrounds, the very nature of love may require an especially faithful attention to such multiplicity. We are ready to acknowledge that, for instance, Dante's meticulously elaborated heaven is governed by love, as the power of love in Dante comes into its own through a wealth of figures and symbols that fill his *Paradiso*.

The present study deals with the idea of love through a diagrammatic figure, the analysis of which may not be as challenging as the interpretation of Dante's *Commedia*, yet still demands a similarly careful consideration of the way this idea comes to the fore through a multiplicity of details. The figure in question is called the *Rotae Ezekiel*, that is, the Wheels of Ezekiel, by virtue of its textual-pictorial connection with the prophet Ezekiel's vision of God's glory descending by a four-wheeled chariot (Ezekiel 1).¹ The figure of the Wheels of Ezekiel was designed by the Calabrian abbot and theologian, Joachim of Fiore (c. 1135-1202). It forms part of a collection of diagrammatic figures, the

¹ See the figure at the end of the article, which is a reproduction of Tavola XV from L. Tondelli, M. Reeves, B. Hirsch-Reich, *Il libro delle figure dell'abate Gioacchino da Fiore*, vol. II, Torino 1953.



Liber Figurarum, which, put together possibly by his disciples after his death, consists of diagrams Joachim drew throughout his career as an interpreter of the Scriptures.²

In an abstract diagrammatic way, representing the chariot of Ezekiel's vision, Joachim's figure groups concepts of biblical origin around the concept of love, which occupies the centre of the figure by a caption written in capital letters: CARITAS. The figure embodies a subtle dialectic between the oneness of its central caption and the multiplicity of its further captions that, with few exceptions, are arranged along a horizontal and a vertical axis. This cruciform structure of captions and interwoven circles (two major concentric circles bear four minor ones) offers the concept of love an intricate context. In interpreting this diagram, my task is not far from what Joachim himself says when commenting upon Ezekiel's vision: «Let us also strive to see with subtlety, as a gift from God, everything that the prophet Ezekiel saw, so that, through the multiple ways (*per multa itinera*) of concords, we are able to come to a unified knowledge (*ad unam notitiam*) of truth».³

It is this «unified knowledge of truth» through «the multiple ways of concords» that, with its focus on a central caption and its fourfold way of arranging further inscriptions, Joachim's figure invites us to discover.

1. *Rotae Ezekiel: Quaternities*

The basic framework of the figure is made up of the captions spelling out those four faces that each of the four «living creatures»

² It is one of Marco Rainini's main theses in his book on Joachim's figures (*Disegni dei tempi: Il "Liber Figurarum" e la teologia figurativa di Gioacchino da Fiore*, Roma 2006), that, in contrast to what earlier research by Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich claimed about its being an organised unity devised by Joachim himself or a close disciple of his during his lifetime, the *Liber Figurarum* is a loose collection, the archetype of which was a kind of *portfolio* of the Abbot's figures compiled by his disciples after his death. As Rainini puts it, a proper title for this collection would be «the book of Figures» rather than «the Book of figures». See *Ibidem*, 233-240, and especially 240. Cfr. M. Reeves, B. Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore*, Oxford 1972, 94-98, 112-119.

³ «(...) totam illam quam vidit Ezechiel propheta nos quoque pro dono Dei videre subtiliter studeamus: quatenus per multa concordiarum itinera ad unam veritatis notitiam pervenire possimus». Joachim of Fiore, *Liber Concordie*, Venice 1519, f. 112va. This passage is quoted by Reeves, Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae*, cit., 227.



(following each wheel of God's chariot) has in Ezekiel's vision. If we read them clockwise starting from the right side of the diagram, they appear in the following order: *Homo* (Man), *Vitulus* (which means calf, although Ezekiel's narrative refers to the face of an ox), *Leo* (Lion), and *Aquila* (Eagle).⁴ Apparently, the diagram does not represent the whole of the vision, since it does not feature the four living creatures with their respective wheels, but only the four faces that each living creature has. At any rate, the textual connection of the figure with the Book of Ezekiel and its divine chariot becomes even stronger by a quote of verses 1:15-16, which lies in the middle of the figure around the caption *CARITAS*. This quote envisions each wheel's structure as a double wheel, as *rota in medio rotae* («a wheel in the middle of a wheel»), which in all likelihood relates to the two major concentric circles of the diagram. Joachim's figure features a single one of the four double wheels, each of which is associated with a living creature with four faces.

This framework provided by Ezekiel gives a foundational meaning to the central caption. The prophet's vision is about the descent of God's glory on God's people, which Joachim also strives to see, as he himself says in the above-cited passage, *pro dono Dei*, that is, as a gift from God. God's epiphany, through a revelation in a prophet's vision, is a gift from God and a sign of God's love for his people. Accordingly, what *Caritas* in the middle of Joachim's figure primarily means is God's love, which becomes manifest through those multiple diagrammatic relations that the figure includes as its message. Indeed, the diagram mediates God's love for the viewer who contemplates it, and thereby comes to experience an inner transformation.

The quaternity of the faces of the living creatures establishes a structure based on the number four: the captions around the central caption *CARITAS* form groups of four in concord with *Homo*, *Vitulus*, *Leo*, and *Aquila*. As we move clockwise from the right side and also from the circumference to the centre, the groups are the following:

⁴ Cfr. Ezekiel 1:10.



*Groups of inscriptions outside the circles*

	MAN	CALF	LION	EAGLE
<i>deeds of Christ</i> <i>(opera Christi)</i>	By his birth, Christ became man: from this event a lot of men were born.	By his death, Christ became a (sacrificial) calf: so it is that, on the altar of Christ, a lot of calves were sacrificed.	By his resurrection, Christ became a lion: so it is that the courage of faith made a lot of lions appear.	By his ascension to heaven, Christ became an eagle: so it is that a lot of eagles came into being.
<i>historical orders</i>	Man designates the order of the doctors.	Calf designates the order of the martyrs.	Lion designates the order of the pastors.	Eagle designates the order of the contemplatives.

*Groups of captions and inscriptions inside the circles*

	MAN	CALF	LION	EAGLE
<i>the senses of Scripture</i>	moral sense	historical sense	typical sense	contemplative or anagogical sense
<i>the pairs of two cities: Jerusalem/Babylon</i>	Jerusalem: faithful soul Babylon: soul who abandoned faith	Jerusalem: virgin dedicated to Christ Babylon: virgin who is like a desperate prostitute	Jerusalem: Roman Church Babylon: Rome as persecutor of the Church	Jerusalem: celestial city Babylon: infernal chaos
<i>deeds of Christ</i> <i>(opera Christi)</i>	Here Christ is born.	Here Christ suffered.	Here Christ resurrected.	Here Christ ascended to heaven.
<i>virtues</i>	Humility	Patience	Faith	Hope





It was from the patristic age that Joachim inherited the idea of arranging various quaternities around the four faces of Ezekiel's living creatures (in this regard, patristic authors also made use of their four wings).⁵ Moreover, not only this idea, but also most of the groups themselves originate from patristic authors. However, we cannot find in any author the same combination of fourfold groups as in Joachim's figure. It is also important to note that the application of the historical orders and the typological pairs of Jerusalem/Babylon to this context is likely to be Joachim's invention.

In what follows I will present, step by step, the various components of Joachim's figure as displayed in the table above.

1. As emerging in inscriptions both outside and inside the circles of the figure, it is no exaggeration to say that the deeds of Christ form the most significant group of four.⁶ These four deeds represent the basic redemptive events of Christ's earthly life. Their association with Ezekiel's living creatures can be traced back to Gregory the Great,⁷ and their contemplation as salvific deeds became especially important in 12th century Cistercian literature.⁸

2. The historical orders are various groups of the faithful who have appeared throughout the history of the Church. While they are well attested to in several works of Joachim, it is perhaps a passage from his *Expositio in Apocalypsim* that is most relevant in the context of the *Rotae Ezekiel*.⁹ In this passage, Joachim associates these historical orders with the four living creatures that, according to verse 4:6 of the Revelations of John, stand around the heavenly throne of God. (Verse 4:7 makes clear that John's vision rests upon Ezekiel's: John's living creatures look like a lion, an ox, a man, and an eagle). According to the same passage, the four living creatures form allegorical pairs with the four beasts from the Book of Daniel which come to represent various historical groups which persecuted the Church. These four pairs of living creatures and beasts (that is, historical orders and persecutors) provide a relevant background to the understanding of the historical orders in the figure of the *Rotae Ezekiel*, as we read them counter-clockwise from the left side:

⁵ Cfr. Rainini, *Disegni*, cit., 146-147.

⁶ Cfr. Reeves, Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae*, cit., 225-226.

⁷ See Rainini, *Disegni*, cit., 146-147.

⁸ See the subsection *From «carnal love» to «spiritual love»* below.

⁹ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, Venice 1527, fol. 162 vb. This passage has been interpreted by Rainini, *Disegni*, cit., 159.



<i>Revelations</i> 4:6-7 and <i>Ezekiel Ch. 1:</i> <i>Historical</i> <i>orders of the</i> <i>Church</i>	LION: Apostles	CALF: Evangelists, Deacons and Martyrs	MAN: Doctors	EAGLE: Hermits
<i>Daniel 7:2-7:</i> <i>Persecutors of</i> <i>the Church</i>	LIONESS: Jews	BEAR: Pagans	LEOPARD: Arians	FOURTH BEAST («different from all the others»): Saracens

3. Although Joachim's understanding of the senses of Scripture as presented in his works is rather complex and not always consistent,¹⁰ the way it emerges in his figure of the *Rotae Ezekiel* is in partial agreement with the four senses of patristic and medieval tradition, originating from Augustine and Bede the Venerable. (There was also a tradition of threefold interpretation which stemmed from Jerome, who had been influenced in turn by Origen and Philo.¹¹) The fourfold understanding of Scripture in medieval scholarship drew distinctions between a literal or historical, an allegorical, a moral or tropological, and an anagogical sense. The degree to which this fourfold understanding is relevant to Joachim's own quaternity of the senses in his figure can best be demonstrated through the four meanings that the Jerusalem/Babylon pair acquire.

4. In the right-hand circle of Joachim's figure (in the circle belonging to the *intelligentia moralis*), Jerusalem and Babylon are presented, on the one hand, as «faithful soul» and, on the other, as a «soul who abandoned faith», which is in full concord with the traditional moral sense in the medieval understanding of Scripture: the two

¹⁰ An elaborate exposition of this fundamental aspect of Joachim's thought can be found in Bernard McGinn's monograph: *The Calabrian Abbot: Joachim of Fiore in the History of Western Thought*, New York 1985, 123-144.

¹¹ See *The Didascalicon of Hugh of Saint Victor: a Medieval Guide to the Arts*, ed. by J. Taylor, New York 1991, 219, n. 1.



great cities of Old Testament history come to foreshadow opposing moral conditions of the individual soul.¹²

In the lower circle, that is, the circle of the *intelligentia historica*, Jerusalem emerges as a «virgin dedicated to Christ», while Babylon appears as a «virgin who is like a desperate prostitute». These meanings do not coincide with the traditional historical sense, according to which Jerusalem and Babylon should figure here as themselves, that is, as historical cities in the Old Testament. What, however, this «historical sense» of the two cities reflects here is Joachim's understanding of it as a kind of «moralising spiritual sense» rather than a «literal sense» (as in the case of other medieval authors). When elaborating on his concept of *intelligentia historica*, Joachim himself draws a distinction between the letter of history and «historical reality», the latter of which implies a «movement toward the freedom of contemplation and full spiritual understanding».¹³

In the left-hand circle that belongs to *intelligentia tipica*, Jerusalem and Babylon have a kind of typological sense: the former prefigures the «Roman Church», while the latter foreshadows «Rome as persecutor of the Church» (which may mean both the ancient Roman Empire and the Holy Roman Empire of the Germans in its conflict with the Holy See). We may make two comments about this. Firstly, this sense is close to what the traditional fourfold division of the scriptural senses understood as an allegorical sense. Secondly, however, it is quite far from what, in his works, Joachim usually meant by *intelligentia tipica*: this should be a sevenfold sense pertaining to the seven ages of Church history and also reflecting seven possible combinations from the inner life of the Trinity.¹⁴

In the upper circle representing the *intelligentia contemplativa sive anagogica* of the two cities, Jerusalem proves a «celestial city» (which is a clear reference to the heavenly Jerusalem at the end of times), whereas Babylon turns out to be an «infernal chaos» (which, in opposition to the heavenly Jerusalem, will mean the eternal flames

¹² In his monograph about the *Liber Figurarum*, Marco Rainini drew a similar conclusion as to the moral sense of the first pair of Jerusalem/Babylon: cfr. Rainini, *Disegni*, cit., 159.

¹³ See McGinn, *The Calabrian Abbot*, cit., 131. Cfr. Joachim of Fiore, *Liber Concordie*, f. 60v: «Quidem autem putant hystoricam intelligentiam esse ipsam hystoriam que vocatur littera, sed non est ita: aliud est enim hystoria, alia hystorica res».

¹⁴ See Joachim of Fiore, *Liber Concordie*, f. 61rv; *Expositio*, f. 26va; and *Psalterium decem chordarum*, ed. K.-V. Selge, Rome 2009, 243-249. Cfr. Rainini, *Disegni*, cit., 158, and McGinn, *The Calabrian Abbot*, cit., 132-133.





of hell). In this circle, the two cities have a signification which is in full agreement with what medieval theologians understood by the anagogical sense, embodying the eschatological meaning of biblical entities. This sense can also be called contemplative, as it promotes the contemplation of things to come.

The captions of «Jerusalem» and «Babylon» appear again in the centre of the figure, forming a quadrangle with the captions of «Sarah» and «Agar». This linkage provides a further confirmation as to the reading of the fourfold pair of Jerusalem/Babylon. In his Letter to the Galatians, the apostle Paul views Sarah and Agar as allegories of the two Covenants (4:21-31). Sarah, who is Abraham's wife and a «free woman», represents the New Covenant of the Christians and «Jerusalem which is above» (4:26); Agar, who is Abraham's servant, represents the Old Covenant at Mount Sinai and «Jerusalem which is now» (4:25), that is, the Synagogue of the Jews. This connection with Paul's allegory provides the pair of Jerusalem and Babylon with a clear typological dimension, by which they come to encapsulate the history of salvation, extending from Old Testament cities to the «celestial city» and the «infernal chaos».

5. There remains one fourfold group that, as yet, I have not interpreted: the quaternity of virtues inscribed in capital letters in the four minor circles of Joachim's diagram. Here, «Humility», «Patience», «Faith» and «Hope» are not virtues in a general sense. Rather, they have the specific meaning of Christ's virtues, and are closely connected with the four salvific deeds of Christ, as passages from Joachim's *Expositio in Apocalypsim* make clear. The two salvific virtues of humility and patience belong to the humanity of Christ, who, by his birth and death, gave these virtues as gift (*donum*) to the faithful. It was also by way of a gift that Christ provided the faithful with the virtues of faith and hope: these latter virtues pertain to his divinity which became manifest in his resurrection and ascension.¹⁵

In the light of these virtues of Christ, given to those whom he saved, the central caption CARITAS may come to the fore as Christ's fifth and most fundamental virtue. Indeed, given its central position, it is Christ's love as his fifth virtue that crowns not only the fourfold group of his virtues, but also all the quaternities arranged around it. Christ's love is the very centre, to which all his deeds, all the historical orders of the Church, all the senses of Scripture and also all

¹⁵ See Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, f. 106vb-108ra. Cfr. *Psalterium decem chordarum*, cit., 118-119, and also Rainini, *Disegni*, cit., 157.



the typological meanings of Jerusalem and Babylon relate. Moreover, Christ's love should also be a *donum* like all the other virtues of his: all the quaternities point toward this central gift, by which those who believe in Christ are able to love as Christ loved them. Since the fours of the *Rotae Ezekiel* imply a strong historical dimension, it is also fair to say that this central gift of love is the historical fulfilment and also historical ground of the process they represent.

The historical dimension of Christ's *donum* of love will become especially relevant if we consider that this fifth and final gift may be understood as that of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost. Indeed, it is exactly in the context of Ezekiel's, and also John's, vision of the living creatures¹⁶ that, in his *Liber de concordia Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*, Joachim refers to this gift as a fifth deed of Christ: «As there are four living creatures, there were first four deeds in Christ: birth, passion, resurrection, and ascension, and then followed the gift of the Holy Spirit in the fifth place. It is the gift that properly belongs to the throne of God».¹⁷

The central caption CARITAS in Joachim's figure may stand for this gift of the Holy Spirit, which, as a consequence, would occupy the throne of God in the middle of the figure, inasmuch as we regard its four minor circles as the four wheels of the chariot. This identification of the Holy Spirit with the virtue of love is made more explicit in a passage from the *Psalterium decem chordarum*, in which Joachim links the three «theological virtues» with the Persons of the Trinity: while the virtues of faith and hope pertain to the Father and the Son, the virtue of love belongs to the Holy Spirit.¹⁸

It is not only the descent of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost that gives Christ's virtue and gift of love a historical character. In Joachim's doctrine of history, the pneumatological event at Pentecost is also a

¹⁶ Cfr. p. 5 above.

¹⁷ «Precesserunt enim in Christo quatuor opera, secundum quod quatuor sunt animalia: nativitas, passio, resurrectio, et ascensio, et secutum est in quinto gradu donum Spiritus Sancti, hoc est illud donum quod proprie pertinet ad sedem Dei». Joachim of Fiore, *Liber de Concordia Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*, ed. by E. Randolph Daniel, Philadelphia 1983), 211.

¹⁸ «Et notandum quod [...] videntur pertinere [...] fides scilicet ad Patrem, quia ipsa est fundamentum virtutum sicut et Pater principium in deitate, spes ad Filium, qui veniens in mundum promisit nobis regnum et futuram vitam, caritas ad Spiritum sanctum qui datus est nobis, ut diffunderetur ipsa caritas in cordibus nostris». *Psalterium decem chordarum*, cit., 223. Cfr. Rainini, *Disegni*, cit., 157-158, and Reeves, Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae*, cit., 229.



prefiguration of what will happen at the end of the present age, which is also the beginning of the final age of history. The final age will come under the auspices of the Holy Spirit, and then the whole of this age will belong to Him. Accordingly, Christ's gift of love through the Holy Spirit implies a double fulfilment: it can be the fulfilment of Christ's earthly life at the first Pentecost and also the fulfilment of the earthly course of his Church at the great final Pentecost of history. The earthly course of the Church repeats what happened to Christ in his earthly life. She undergoes a birth, a passion, a resurrection, an ascension, and a Pentecost as her Master did.¹⁹ This is the reason why the inscriptions in Joachim's figure of the *Rotae Ezekiel* make such an intimate connection between the deeds of Christ and the historical orders of the Church. Both the former and the latter point toward the same multiple centre of love which is the fulfilment both of Scripture and of the history of salvation.

2. The power and weakness of number

No doubt Joachim's figure can be viewed as a concentric structure, all members of which point to the centre, that is, the gift of God's or Christ's love. However, one may ask whether this centre is powerful enough to maintain the whole structure. In other words, one may raise doubts about the centre's capability of explaining relations between the members of the structure. For instance, what is the reason of some combinations of the scriptural senses with the faces of the living creatures? (For example, why is it that the *intelligentia historica* is linked with *Vitulus*?). What links some deeds of Christ to the respective pair of Jerusalem and Babylon? (For example, what does Christ's birth have to do with Jerusalem as «faithful soul» and Babylon as a «soul who abandoned faith»?). We may conclude that Joachim's figure displays some connections which neither love as its centre nor any other conceptual relation can explain.

It seems that what helps the centre and the various conceptual relations hold the diagram together is nothing but the power of number, that is, in the present case, the power of number four. The number four functions here as a «sufficient reason» of Joachim's diagram. It is the number four that maintains the logic of the figure at those

¹⁹ Cfr. Joachim of Fiore, *Tractatus super quatuor evangelia*, a cura di F. Santi, Roma 2002, 238.



points where nothing else does. What matters is the fact that each group of concepts is a fourfold one, even if the matrix-like arrangement of the groups can bring about some haphazard constellations between respective group members.

As the figure of the *Rotae Ezekiel* bears a special significance among Joachim's diagrams by being organised according to one single number, so we find that a numerical approach is especially characteristic of Joachim's thought in general. In Joachim, the various entities of Scripture and the history of salvation form an order, whose principle is the systematic recurrence of certain number patterns. Henry Mottu's and Marco Rainini's insight into Joachim's thought as that of a «calculating exegete» is in profound correspondence with what Bernard McGinn sees as the «living order of reason» (*vivens ordo rationis*), an organising principle which permeates Joachim's vision of history.²⁰ It is Joachim himself who, in his *Tractatus super quatuor evangelia*, makes this connection between *ordo* and *numerus*: «Definite and equal number is given to the distinct events of the three ages, in order that we understand that God's works imply a kind of living order, through which we can comprehend many things according to their appointed times».²¹

We can comprehend the three ages of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit as God's numerical works, for God imposed a «living order» on history by appointing «definite and equal» number patterns to emerge in each historical period.

Focused on Christ, Scripture and the history of salvation as it is, the numerical concern and the related geometrical array of Joachim's *Rotae Ezekiel* give the impression of what may be called a «cosmic order». And this impression is especially well-founded as regards the fact that it is the number four upon which the order of the figure rests. The number four emerged as sacred as early as ancient Egyptian astrology,²² and it had an unbroken career up until the Europe-

²⁰ See H. Mottu, *La manifestation de l'Esprit selon Joachim de Fiore: Herméneutique et théologie de l'histoire d'après le Traité sur les quatre evangiles*, Paris-Neuchâtel 1977, 121; Rainini, *Disegni*, cit., 18-21; and B. McGinn, *Ratio and Visio: Reflections on Joachim of Fiore's Place in Twelfth-Century Theology*, in *Gioacchino da Fiore tra Bernardo di Clairvaux e Innocenzo III*, a cura di R. Rusconi, Roma 2001, 27-46, at 34-37, 38-39.

²¹ «Certus autem et equalis numerus datus est singulis trium etatum, ut intelligamus esse quemdam viventem ordinem in operibus divinis, per quem possint multa comprehendere in temporibus suis», Joachim of Fiore, *Tractatus*, cit., 18.

²² See the quote from Hopper below.





an Middle Ages. Turning from an astrological-astronomical number symbol into an all-comprising cosmological principle, the number four well exemplifies the cultural fate of other sacred numbers, too (such as, for instance, the numbers seven and twelve). This fate is properly formulated in a passage of Vincent Foster Hopper's *Medieval Number Symbolism*:

Apart from any special creations of number symbols, the overwhelming importance of the astrological concept to number symbolism lay in the belief that the stars imaged the will of the gods, and that in the sacred number groups might be found the impress of the divine hand. Consequently, having discovered 4 directions and 4 lunar phases, man diligently pursued the search for other examples of quaternity in the universe. He soon educed 4 winds, then 4 seasons, then 4 watches of the day and night, then 4 elements and 4 humours and 4 cardinal virtues. Seneca made a rather keen guess when he assigned the discovery of the 4 elements to the Egyptians, since Egypt appears to have been more conscious of this number than any other nation.²³

However important Egyptian culture was as a source for a quadripartite organisation of the universe, the European Middle Ages was also rich in various textual and visual schemes of both biblical and cosmic quaternities. With regard to diagrammatic figures, medieval illuminators produced plenty that unified the two worlds of nature and Scripture through a number of fourfold correspondences.²⁴ Besides the above-cited cosmic fours, these correspondences also included quaternities of biblical origin such as the four Gospels, the four extremities of the cross or the four senses of Scripture.

Although the Oxford manuscript of the *Rotae Ezekiel* figure (which can be found in Corpus Christi College, MS 255A, f. 16v., the version we have interpreted so far) does not contain an explicit reference to the fact that its numerical design is a cosmological one, there is another version of the figure which, as a late re-interpretation of the *Rotae Ezekiel*, points to the presence of such a dimension. What the Venetian printed edition of the *Expositio* and the *Psalterium* from 1527 assigns to the four cardinal points of Joachim's figure is not the four faces of the living creatures, but captions spelling out the four re-

²³ V. Foster Hopper, *Medieval Number Symbolism: Its Sources, Meaning, and Influence on Thought and Expression*, New York 1969, 14. Cfr. 8, 28, 84.

²⁴ Anna C. Esmeijer's book entitled *Divina Quaternitas: A Preliminary Study in the Method and Application of Visual Exegesis*, Assen-Amsterdam 1978, abounds with examples of such figures.



gions of the world: *Occidens* (West), *Aquilo* (North), *Oriens* (East), and *Meridies* (South).²⁵ This replacement of the four living creatures with the four regions may be viewed as a consequent one, if we consider that the living creatures «can be traced back to astronomical origins in remote antiquity», and «they represent the four stars of the seasons and so the four cardinal points of the compass».²⁶ What can also make the cosmological dimension of Joachim's figure a stronger case is the fact that his writings also include passages that relate biblical quaternities to cosmological ones.²⁷

As reflected in the diagram of the *Rotae Ezekiel*, the number four seems to fulfil what Ernst Cassirer recognised as the secret of the mythical power of numbers in Antiquity and the Middle Ages: that numbers are capable of binding together the greatest multiplicity and difference in the universe, and thereby function as a unifying instrument, and may even appear as the truth itself.²⁸ According to Cassirer's interpretation of mythical thought, the principle of number takes all profane being into «the mythical-religious process of sanctification», so that, «in a way similar to what Plato's *eros* does, it becomes a great mediator, through which the earthly and the divine, the mortal and the immortal communicate with each other and form a unity that is the unity of a world order (*sich zur Einheit einer Weltordnung zusammenfaßt*)».²⁹

Still, in the context of the Christian doctrine of creation, the unification of «the earthly and the divine, the mortal and the immortal» by number cannot go too far. Christian doctrine professes the transcendence of an everlasting Creator who called the universe into being without mingling or «getting unified» with it. Translating this act of creation into numerical terms, we can say with an authority such as Augustine that God created the world according to transcendent archetypal numbers in God's mind. For instance, in Augustine's

²⁵ See Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, f. 226v. As a matter of fact, the Oxford manuscript is much closer to what Joachim intended to say. The figure in the Venetian edition has almost no significance as a proof of what Joachim had in mind. However, this figure has significance in its own right as an important moment in the course of the reception history of Joachim's *Rotae Ezekiel* diagram. It points to the cosmological dimension which is incipient in the Oxford figure.

²⁶ Reeves, Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae*, cit., 225, n. 6.

²⁷ See, for instance, *Liber Concordie*, f. 61va and f. 102 vb-103ra. Cfr. Rainini, *Disegni*, cit., 152-155.

²⁸ E. Cassirer, *Philosophie der symbolischen Formen*, vol. II, *Das mythische Denken*, Darmstadt 1997, 169, 171.

²⁹ Cassirer, *Das mythische Denken*, cit., 173-174.



opinion, the reason why God completed the work of creation in six days is that six is an especially perfect number among the archetypical numbers.³⁰ In like manner, it is the archetypical number four in God's mind that comes to be reflected by way of respective number patterns in the cosmic order and the order of Scripture. On the one hand, however, the archetypical numbers remain transcendent in their relation to those numbers that are in the universe and in Scripture, and, on the other, Augustine himself quotes Psalms 147:5 to prove that God is superior to any number: «Great is our Lord and his power is great, / and his wisdom does not have any number».³¹

While its capability of unifying the created order of the world and Scripture bears witness to the power of number, it is still its «weakness» that ensues from the cleft of transcendence between God and God's creation. Although the act of creation can, to some degree, be expressed in numerical terms, this numerical process of creation cannot explain why it came about at all, that is, why God loved the universe and decided to create it despite the cleft implied in this act on account of God's transcendence. Furthermore, when it comes to God's love as realised in the history of salvation and particularly in Christ, the weakness of numbers to explain this love becomes even more obvious.

Dependent upon unifying numerical correspondences as Joachim's figure is, it bears great significance that the central caption CARITAS as the fifth virtue and fifth deed of Christ breaks the matrix-like series of quaternities. The fourfold groups of the figure may represent Scripture and the history of salvation in the fashion of a

³⁰ Augustine makes this reference in his *De genesi ad litteram*: see *La genèse au sens littéral en douze livres*, vol. I, éd. par P. Agaësse, A. Solignac, (Oeuvres de Saint Augustin, 48) Paris 2000, 298-299. Cfr. H. Meyer, *Die Zahlenallegorese im Mittelalter: Methode und Gebrauch*, München 1975, 30-31. The idea of the number six as a perfect number can be traced back to Neo-Pythagorean number theory, according to which «perfect number is [...] one whose divisors add up to the number itself; for example, the divisors of 6 are 1, 2, 3, and 1+2+3=6». Hopper, *Medieval Number Symbolism*, cit., 37. Meyer gives the same explanation: Meyer, *Die Zahlenallegorese*, cit., 30.

³¹ See Augustine's *In Iohannis evangelium Tractatus CXXIV*, ed. R. Willems, (Corpus Christianorum Series Latina, 36) Turnhout 1954, 346-347. Cfr. Meyer, *Die Zahlenallegorese*, cit., 31. I am quoting Psalms 147:5 according to the Vulgate version, that is, the version used by Augustine: «Magnus Dominus noster et magna virtus ejus, / et sapientiae ejus non est numerus». (Note that this verse is Psalms 146:5 in the Vulgate). For example, the New International Version translates this verse as «Great is our Lord and mighty in power, / his understanding has no limit».



cosmic order, but the interpretation of this order should hinge upon its centre rather than its numerical character. The number four may function as a partial truth of the figure by reflecting the archetypal number in God's mind through various quaternities, but it does not explain why these quaternities emerge at all and why they can form a constellation focused on God's love. The quaternities and cosmic order of Joachim's diagram emerge by God's loving act of creation to form a message about God's loving act of salvation.

3. *The figure of the Rotae Ezekiel as symbol*

Whatever we may think of the power and weakness of number in Joachim's *Rotae Ezekiel*, this basic feature of the diagram also bears witness to what Marie-Dominique Chenu called the «symbolist mentality» of the 12th century.³² This mentality remained very common not only among those who were engaged in traditional monastic exegesis, but also among those who came to apply the logical methods of Aristotelian dialectics to the matters of Christian doctrine.

Masters in the schools, mystics, exegetes, students of nature, seculars, religious, writers, and artists – these men of the twelfth century had in common with all other men of the Middle Ages the conviction that all natural and historical reality possessed a *signification* which transcended its crude reality and which a certain symbolic dimension of that reality would reveal to man's mind.³³

A «reality possessing a signification which transcends it» is certainly a rather general formulation, but it definitely captures something of the fascination those living in the culture of the Middle Ages experienced when coming across symbols such as the divine chariot in Ezekiel's vision.

In his Augustinian appropriation of the theology of Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite, however, Hugh of Saint Victor proposed a more precise definition of the symbol, which became famous (and popular among mediaevalists): «A symbol is a juxtaposition, that is, a coaptation of visible forms brought forth to demonstrate some invis-

³² See M.-D. Chenu, *Nature, Man, and Society in the Twelfth Century*, Toronto 1997, 99-145, *passim*.

³³ *Ibidem*, 102.



ible matter».³⁴

What is significant about this definition is its application of the Neo-Platonic principle of *per visibilia ad invisibilia*. This principle played a central role in Victorine pedagogy which made use of visual figures for both didactic and spiritual-contemplative purposes.³⁵ What this definition is also keen to emphasise is the composite nature of the symbol as a «juxtaposition» and «coaptation of visible forms». This emphasis on a composite quality in the realm of the visible has an implicit message about a more simple entity in the realm of the invisible, to which the contemplation of a composite and visible symbol is supposed to lead. Indeed, there is a fundamental insight in Pseudo-Dionysian theology that, by way of contemplation, symbols enable an *anagoge* or ascension, that is, a return from the realm of multiplicity to the divine One.³⁶ Translating this doctrine into the terms of Joachim's figure, we may state that this figure is a symbol composed of a sequence of visible quaternities, which, by way of contemplation, is able to elevate us to the unity of God's love. Following this line of thought, we may also claim that God's love is this symbol's invisible signification, which, however, is visibly indicated by its central caption CARITAS.

Nevertheless, there is some difficulty about such an interpretation of the figure: its embeddedness into the 12th century tradition of diagrammatic figures gives it a kind of conventional character,³⁷ which creates a certain distance between what we see as Joachim's diagram and what we read about God's chariot in Ezekiel. In other words, the figure of the *Rotae Ezekiel* may belong to a world of its

³⁴ «(...) symbolum, collatio videlicet, id est coaptatio visibilium formarum ad demonstrationem rei invisibilis propositarum». See Hugh of Saint Victor, *Expositio in hierarchiam caelestem*, in *Patrologiae cursus completus, Series Latina*, ed. J.-P. Migne, Paris 1844-1855, vol. 175, 960. Chenu cites this definition twice (*Nature, Man, and Society*, cit., 103, 114), and other mediaevalists are also fond of quoting it: cfr. P. Sicard, *Diagrammes médiévaux et exégèse visuelle: le Libellus de formatione arche de Hugues de Saint-Victor*, Paris-Turnhout 1993, 184 and n. 109.

³⁵ *Ibidem*, 171, *passim*.

³⁶ See, for instance, Hugh of Saint Victor, *Expositio*, cit., vol. 175, 1152, and also Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite, *La hiérarchie céleste*, éd. par R. Roques, G. Heil, M. de Gandillac, (Sources Chrétiennes 58) Paris 1958, 70-73. Cfr. R. Roques, *Structures théologiques de la gnose à Richard de Saint-Victor: Essais et analyses critiques*, Paris 1962, 320-321, 329-330.

³⁷ Cfr. Anna C. Esmeijer's claim that «Joachim da Fiore comes at the end of a long evolution in the methods of visual exegesis». *Divina Quaternitas*, cit., 127.



own by obeying more or less fixed rules of the diagrammatic genre,³⁸ which threaten its share of the symbolic force of the chariot that it is supposed to represent. God's chariot in Ezekiel is a powerful symbol, which can easily and rightly be rendered in Pseudo-Dionysian terms: it is a «divine reality», the connection of which with God's heavenly world is that of a full participation rather than a simple «reference».³⁹ While designating this *divinum symbolum*, Joachim's figure functions more like an Augustinian *signum*, which conveys knowledge and operates through a certain disjunction between signifier and signified, which are connected together only by means of convention.⁴⁰ As an integral part of the symbolic mentality of the 12th century, however, the legacy of Augustine's sign theory has a relevance for the interpretation of symbols in a broader sense (such as Joachim's diagram), whereas the Pseudo-Dionysian view of «divine reality» enables us to approach symbols in a narrower sense (such as God's chariot in Ezekiel).

At the same time, Joachim's figure includes a basic component, which, in spite of all its theoretical distance from the symbol of God's chariot, brings it near to the prophet Ezekiel's vision. The inner circle of the diagram bears a quote from Ezekiel's narrative of God's chariot, which means that the diagram includes the medium closest to the chariot, that is, the medium in which the chariot is primarily given to us. This circumstance is a significant indication as to the use of the figure. A contemplation of Joachim's figure as a symbol is appropriate only if accompanied by the reading of Ezekiel's biblical text, that is, by the contemplation of the symbol of the divine chariot through the biblical text.

In the light of this close association with Ezekiel's text and symbol, it becomes clear why a symbolic-anagogical interpretation of the

³⁸ See Sicard, *Diagrammes médiévaux*, cit., 152.

³⁹ An entire branch of Jewish Mysticism as based on the vision of God's chariot in Ezekiel shows how powerful an appeal this symbol had even to Medieval Jewish Cabbalists who contemplated it as an image of the divine sphere. See G. Scholem, *Die jüdische Mystik in ihren Hauptströmungen*, Frankfurt am Main 1980, 43-86.

⁴⁰ This contrast between the Pseudo-Dionysian «symbol» and the Augustinian «sign» has been aptly developed by Chenu: *Nature, Man, and Society*, cit., 124-127. (Chenu's interpretation rests, on the one hand, upon the *De caelesti hierarchia* by Pseudo-Dionysius, and, on the other, upon the *De magistro* and *De doctrina christiana* by Augustine). It is important to note that Augustine's theory of signs remained more influential in the Middle Ages than the Pseudo-Dionysian understanding of symbols. For instance, the former deeply influenced Hugh of Saint Victor in his interpretation of the latter. Cfr. Roques, *Structures théologiques*, cit., 329.



figure is plausible and why its design is so keen to visualise such a powerful anagogical movement as the linear curves around it suggest.

This movement is accentuated by the flowing curves in which the figure is enclosed: at *Homo* a long curve plunges downwards; at *Vitulus* the curve takes the form of a sacrificial bowl; at *Leo* on the left a similar shape is used but suggesting here rather the gathering together of forces for the supreme event; dominating the figure at *Aquila* above is a threefold feature in which two upward-thrusting curves express the subsuming of all things in the divine sphere, culminating in an upward pointer which breaks into three lobes.⁴¹

This final «subsuming of all things» of the figure «in the divine sphere» takes place in the compartment of the Eagle, which includes the fourth and final members of the figure's quaternities such as Christ's ascension, the order of the contemplatives, the heavenly Jerusalem and the anagogical sense of Scripture. Everything points to *anagoge* or ascension here, especially as combined with the upward-thrusting force of the divine symbol in Ezekiel's text. *Anagoge* or ascension as suggested by the corresponding symbols in Joachim and Ezekiel imply both a meaning and an event. *Anagoge* implies a meaning here through the anagogical sense and knowledge carried by Ezekiel's text and Joachim's figure, but *anagoge* also implies an event of ascension as experienced by those who contemplate this anagogical sense and knowledge.⁴²

A view of Joachim's figure as a symbol implying the double *anagoge* of a meaning and an event certainly enriches the message of its central caption *CARITAS*. The concept of love as the centre of the figure may undoubtedly include the event of elevation from the visible quaternities into their invisible unity of God's love, as I stated above. While God's love may definitely appear as such signification of the figure and also destination of the act of elevation or *anagoge*, we should also note that, on account of its precursory *descent* by the divine chariot, God's love is also the initiation of such an act. Furthermore, the contemplative act or event of elevation implies not only God's initial and ultimate love of those who contemplate, but also their love of God, by which they ascend to God: Joachim's figure may

⁴¹ Reeves, Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae*, cit., 226.

⁴² It is in this sense of a meaning and an event that Henri de Lubac talks about a double aspect of the anagogical sense of Scripture. See *Medieval Exegesis: The Four Senses of Scripture*, vol. II, Grand Rapids 1998, 180-182, 188.



be seen as a symbol joining human and divine love. This symbol has the concept of love as its centre fulfilling all the aspects of *anagoge* as an event. Accordingly, *anagoge* as a meaning of Joachim's symbol is fully covered by its central message of love.

4. *From «carnal love» to «spiritual love»*

In talking about *anagoge* as a mystical ascension of humans to God, we should consider both God's love of humans and human love of God. Both kinds of love have a history or process as manifested in Jesus Christ, the God-man, who, in spite of being God, was born and suffered death, and, in spite of being man, was resurrected and ascended to God. While these four mysteries of Christ's life certainly reveal God's love to humans, they are also «saving mysteries», which redeem humans by «educating» their love of God through the phases of an anagogical process.

Such an anagogical and also christological process of human love is one of the major implications of Joachim's diagram, which has a strong emphasis on the concept of love and the four mysteries of Christ's life, and especially on his ascension. Accordingly, the diagram's central caption CARITAS can be read as an invitation for its viewer to ascend in love to a union with God by way of a gradual contemplation of Christ's four mysteries (and also the adjacent quaternities).

The emphasis of Joachim's figure on love and on Christ's four mysteries with a focus on his ascension bears witness to an influence of Cistercian spirituality and especially the mystical theology of the greatest champion of the Cistercian movement, Bernard of Clairvaux. Bernard's teaching on the ascension of human love to God through Christ's saving mysteries⁴³ is likely to have had an impact on Joachim's figure, given the latter's strong attachment to the former's theology and Cistercian spirituality. Besides the very fact that, in a decisive period of his career, Joachim was a Cistercian abbot himself, this strong attachment of his to Bernard and the Cistercians can be seen and proved in various ways. Firstly, it was his long stay in a major

⁴³ A concise and instructive elaboration on this aspect of St. Bernard's theology can be found in Bernard McGinn's magisterial four-volume exposition of Western mysticism: *The Presence of God: A History of Western Christian Mysticism*, vol. II, *The Growth of Mysticism*, London 1994, 174-177.





Cistercian abbey that helped him reach theological maturity and was a springboard of his later international reputation as an interpreter of the Scriptures.⁴⁴ Secondly, at a crucial point of his career, Joachim embraced the idea that the Cistercian order has a world historical role by being the most developed, that is, the most spiritual form of Western monasticism.⁴⁵ Thirdly, Bernard of Clairvaux is one among those few authors whom Joachim explicitly quotes in his work.⁴⁶

The focus given by Joachim's diagram to the concept of love, Christ's four mysteries and especially his ascension perfectly coincides with the teaching of the Cistercians, and particularly of Bernard, about the elevation of the human soul from a «carnal love of Christ» (*amor carnalis Christi*), through his birth and death, to a «spiritual love of Christ» (*amor spiritualis Christi*), through his resurrection, and especially his ascension.⁴⁷ According to Bernard, God descended in Christ to the carnal level, that is, the human level of the flesh, so that humans as carnal beings start to love him in their own manner, that is, in the flesh.

It is [i.e. what Christ did and ordered in the flesh] the main reason why the invisible God wished to be seen in the flesh and to live among humans as a human so that he might return all the affections of carnal humans, who could only love carnally, first to the saving love of his flesh, and thus, little by little, lead them to spiritual love.⁴⁸

Indeed, in Bernard's teaching, the process from *amor carnalis* to *amor spiritualis* takes place along the line formed by Christ's four saving mysteries. Accordingly, this anagogical process of love consists of four levels: the love of Christ's flesh (*caro*) in a carnal way, the love of Christ's spirit in a carnal way, the love of Christ's flesh in a spiritual way, and the love of Christ's spirit in a spiritual way. As God became flesh through Christ's birth, and spoke to people and taught them,

⁴⁴ The Cistercian abbey where he stayed for a year and a half in 1183-1184 was Casamari. Cfr. G.L. Potestà, *Il tempo dell'Apocalisse. Vita di Gioacchino da Fiore*, Roma 2004, 33-34.

⁴⁵ See *ibidem*, 70-73.

⁴⁶ In his *Psalterium decem chordarum*, Joachim quotes several passages from Bernard's *De consideratione*. Cfr. Potestà, *Il tempo*, cit., 39-40.

⁴⁷ Cfr. McGinn's argument in his *Resurrection and Ascension in the Christology of the Early Cistercians*, in «Cîteaux», 30 (1979), 5-22, *passim*, and especially 21-22.

⁴⁸ *Sancti Bernardi Opera*, ed. J. Leclercq et al., vol. I, Romae 1957, p. 118. The quote is from Bernard's *Twentieth Sermon on the Song of Songs*. The English translation of the passage is McGinn's: *The Growth*, cit., 174.



they loved Christ's flesh in a carnal way. As they realised that Christ wants to dedicate the whole of his life to his friends, they started to love his spirit, but still in a carnal way. However, as they recognised the mystery of salvation through Christ's passion and death, they loved his flesh in a spiritual way. Nevertheless, in the wake of Christ's resurrection and ascension, they came to love his spirit in a spiritual way.⁴⁹

It is this anagogical journey from «carnal love» to «spiritual love» through Christ's four deeds as saving mysteries that the viewer of Joachim's figure may contemplate in combination with the adjacent quaternities. This contemplation of the figure creates a bond between Christ and the individual viewer, which, with respect to Bernard's teaching, can also be seen as a bond of solidarity between the former and the latter in their sharing of the mysteries.⁵⁰ It is through solidarity with Christ and through the love of Christ that, in terms of Joachim's figure, the viewer becomes one of the order of contemplatives who ascend to God like «eagles».

5. Conclusion

The central message of love has a rich context in Joachim's figure of the *Rotae Ezekiel*, which consists not only of the geometrical array of various quaternities, but also of the various connotations this central message can acquire. This multiplicity of captions, inscriptions and of the connotations of love finds a proper «juxtaposition» and also unity in Joachim's figure and Ezekiel's vision as symbols. The intertwined double symbol of Joachim's figure and the divine chariot in Ezekiel has the composite function of representing various *descents* and *ascents* that constitute divine and human love. The descent of God to God's people in the prophet's vision, the ascent of Christ to God, the descent of the Holy Spirit as Christ's fifth *donum*, and the ascent or *anagoge* of the human soul to God through Christ's four saving mysteries are all movements of love which are mediated through

⁴⁹ See *Sancti Bernardi Opera*, cit., vol. VI/1, Romae 1970, 368. This argument is from Bernard's *One Hundred and First Sermon* from the collection of his *Sermones de diversis*. Cfr. J.-Ch. Didier, *L'ascension mystique et l'union mystique par l'humanité du Christ selon saint Bernard*, in «La vie spirituelle», Supplement 25 (1930), 140-155, at 147 and McGinn, *The Growth*, cit., 176.

⁵⁰ See McGinn, *Resurrection and Ascension*, cit., 10, 13.



Joachim's and Ezekiel's double symbol. The truth of this symbol as the manifestation of love includes its partial truth of a numerical arrangement which governs the quaternities of Christ's deeds, the historical orders, the senses of Scripture, the pairs of Jerusalem/Babylon and Christ's virtues. What the contemplation of these fourfold groups and thereby the number four itself helps the *anagoge* of human love attain is their unity in God's love.

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Riassunto: Attraverso il titolo centrale di *Caritas*, la figura in forma di diagramma opera di Gioacchino da Fiore nelle *Rotae Ezechielis* contiene un messaggio centrato sull'idea di amore. Questo titolo assume vari significati nel ricco contesto offerto dalla molteplicità degli altri titoli e iscrizioni che costruiscono quella figura. Sebbene la matrice geometrica dei molteplici gruppi di quattro di queste voci e delle iscrizioni costituisca ciò che può essere definito un «ordine cosmico» governato dal numero quattro, tale logica numerica non è sufficiente a spiegare la realtà della figura nel suo complesso. Le *Rotae Ezechielis* dovrebbero essere viste piuttosto come un simbolo secondo il significato medievale, che consente varie discese e salite dell'amore, sia umano sia divino.



